



Multilingual development: English in a global context

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the book concludes with an overview of the five main models that have emerged to explain the learning of multiple languages and the multilingual mind.

A main strength of the book is its interdisciplinary approach. By synthesising research from several fields, Aronin presents a nuanced and holistic understanding of multilingualism. Her approach enables readers to grasp the complex nature of multilingualism and its far-reaching implications for individuals and societies. Although the broad scope means that some topics are only briefly touched upon, the author's perspective should encourage interested readers to explore further. One of the book's few weaknesses is its limited coverage of multilingualism in education. Given the increasing interest here, Aronin's sporadic and cursory treatment of the topic is somewhat surprising – more details about the challenges and benefits of multilingual education would have been valuable.

Overall, however, the book is an excellent resource for anyone interested in the study of multilingualism. Its comprehensive and interdisciplinary coverage, and its pedagogical features, make it both informative and enjoyable.

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Readers may ask how a study of multilingual development might take the accelerating global influence of English as a major topic. Its progressive penetration into virtually every historically non-English-speaking region of the world is described by the author, detailing the various kinds of language interaction and change that researchers have examined. The subtitle of the book thus follows logically and coherently from the 'Multilingualism' of the title. Chapter 1 begins with the 'special status' of English, unprecedented in every aspect, and Chapter 7 concludes on the same theme. The learning of English as a foreign or second language (L2) – and even as early childhood bilingual development – around the world is one of the most important motors of multilingualism. As the many examples show, especially those from Eastern and Southern Asia, this is because monolingual and bilingual speakers often learn English as their third language.

A notable feature of Siemund's wide-ranging survey is the comparison and correlation of sociolinguistic features of language contact with psycholinguistic mechanisms of acquisition and learning. We need to pay attention, for example, when the terms 'monolingual' and 'bilingual/multilingual' make reference to communities and when they refer to internal cognitive processes.

In regard to the latter, Chapter 3 mentions in passing the Full Transfer/Full Access (FTFA) hypothesis, in a section on transfer between first-language (L1) and second-language competence. 'Full Access' refers to the continuing availability, undiminished by age-of-onset of L2, to the naturally powerful acquisition mechanisms of the language faculty. 'Full Transfer' recognises the research findings on the interactions of language subsystems, on the influences of the L1 mental grammar on the construction of the L2 subsystem. The FTFA framework provides a theoretical backdrop to the extensive discussion throughout the book on Cross Language Influence, or Interaction (CLI). Given that the first language enjoys the 'privileged status as a native language' (83), it is

indeed difficult (we could venture to say impossible) to set aside or ignore the beginning state of mother-tongue competence for the learning of all subsequent languages. In L2 learning, this competence is crucially *specific to the L1 subsystem*, to the specific structures of the L1 mental grammar as these came to be instantiated during L1 acquisition. Theories that attempt to minimise the effects of transfer (including those that deny the separate mental representation of the L1 subsystem) have a steep empirical hill to climb.

The many aspects of CLI are central to the overarching theme of sociolinguistic-cognitive interface. Chapter 1 is mainly focused on the population-wide social relationships of language change, and introduces two important concepts related to CLI. Contrary to early theories of bilingualism that warned us about an ill-defined disruptive interference between the developing languages, recent research on childhood bilingualism has confirmed a remarkably early separation of the two linguistic subsystems – this representing today's broad and virtually unanimous consensus among specialists in the field. The related understanding of uneven bilingual development (dominant language subsystem and relatively weaker subsystem) has come to explain a host of learning phenomena such as the prevailing (but by no means constant) direction of CLI and L1 attrition. Here, attrition is better understood as 'displacement' or 'shift', because the language acquisition/learning capacity, provided by nature, is not diminished in any way. The only exception is trauma to the brain.

Chapter 2 deals with the interactions between the linguistic domain (bilingual and multilingual) and general cognition, with particular attention to executive function. For example, bilinguals need to reduce the interference effects between the two language subsystems in both listening and speaking. Managing this kind of CLI should be related to the development of higher levels of inhibitory control. In this domain, and in other cognitive processes, the research tends to show mixed results about a possible bilingual or multilingual advantage. One reason, perhaps, is because monolinguals also engage in similar types of cognitively enriching activity, in only one language. Processing two languages may therefore offer one type of enrichment among the cognitive challenges that are also available to monolinguals, including the implementation of inhibitory control.

Chapter 3 is dedicated entirely to the investigations on CLI *per se*. An interesting finding in some studies points to a greater CLI effect in L3 learning that can be traced to the L2, as opposed to the L1. An explanation might be that the L2 and L3 subsystems share a mental architecture that is more similar, that depended to a greater degree during development on cognitive-general learning, in contrast to the greater weight of domain-specific acquisition mechanisms in L1. In this case, we must also consider an evaluation of which of the two prior established language subsystems of the L3 learner is in effect the dominant language. The 'chronological' L2 may have displaced the L1 by means of 'replacing language development' (also known as 'attrition'), and may have become the 'new' L1. Siemund's thorough review of the literature on L2 and L3 learning is a welcome addition to our background knowledge of the research base.

The next three chapters complete the review of the psycholinguistic literature and take us back to the still unresolved questions of language use in society. The realms of research complement each other here, as in the role that CLI plays in additive and subtractive bilingualism. In L2 learning, which instances of transfer can we identify as 'facilitative' and which as 'interference'? In the 'other direction', from L2 to L1 – as in language shift – which transfer processes facilitate or hasten replacement of L1 grammatical domains by L2 counterparts? In learning/teaching situations, of course, we also know that interference-type transfer (sometimes termed 'negative') that results in performance error can also be productive as it is a facilitative part of the learning process. Likewise, how do the same CLI processes participate in the creation of new language varieties (via convergence for example) in the widely studied cases of English-based creoles and stable colloquial forms in East Asia?

A number of important concepts are explained clearly: additive/subtractive bilingualism and the related learning outcome of language dominance, cognitive academic language proficiency (related term: register), metalinguistic awareness, critical period, universal linguistic core, the Language

Acquisition Device, heritage bilingualism, the distinction between competence and performance, and the misconceptions emanating from the unfortunate coining many years ago of the term ‘semi-lingualism’. The passages on ‘translanguaging’, in contrast, are difficult to follow. But as many readers familiar with the ‘loosely structured chaos’ (243) of post-modern theorising can attest, the confusion is not mainly Siemund’s fault.

The way that the author has framed the problem of multilingualism has presented us with a dilemma. Just as during an earlier expansion of scholarship and learning – when East Asia and Europe each needed their *lingua franca* – today’s global imperative for a language of international communication has selected English. At the same time as English-language venues have become the indispensable tool of research and cross-cultural discussion in almost every discipline, they have also suffered the effects of an impending corruption, particularly in academia. More than for any other major or cross-national language, publication in English, in print and online, has become the favoured channel for propagating a new genre of pseudo-science and anti-scientific critique of the advances of the Enlightenment. Depending on the prospects for greater plurality, a shift towards a new international linguistic multi-polarity may not be as impractical as it once appeared to be. This last observation is not from Siemund’s concluding chapter, and he may not agree. But the dilemma has been posed.

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Multidisciplinary Perspectives on Multilingualism: The Fundamentals, edited by Simona Montanari and Suzanne Quay, Berlin and Boston, Mouton De Gruyter, 2021, viii + 422 pp., €119.95 / \$124.99 (hbk), €29.95 / \$30.99 (pbk), ISBN: 978-1-5015-1650-4, ISBN: 978-1-5015-2538-4

Multilingualism is typical of everyday life for many populations around the world. It is far from a simple phenomenon, however, as it comprises a vast number of linguistic and extra-linguistic elements. This much-needed collection sets out to explore the complexity of multilingualism through a multidisciplinary lens. In their introduction, Quay and Montanari explicitly state that multilingualism should not be seen as a variant of bilingualism: it should be defined and studied on the basis of its own special qualities and specificities, not because of a connection with bilingualism or as a complement to research on bilingual populations or individuals.

In the first chapter, the editors present the four parts of the book. Part 1 addresses societal multilingualism, focusing on four geographical areas: North Africa, Southeast Asia, Europe and North America. These chapters can offer only an overview of various manifestations of multilingualism in these different areas, of course, and do not pretend to be exhaustive. They do however provide a useful background for the following sections. One argument that struck me – and which is well conveyed in Part 1 – is that multilingualism is a strongly ideological and social phenomenon. As suggested by Ahmed Ech-Charfi in his chapter on French, Arabic and Berber as linguistic resources available to North African speakers, language (and multilingualism) ‘cannot be studied satisfactorily if the ideological processes involved in its construction are ignored’ (24).

In Part 2, Chapters 6 to 9 examine ‘novel concepts and practices’ (2) in the use of more than two languages in multilingual communities: diglossia, codeswitching, receptive multilingualism, and